ENGLISH LANGUAGE & LINGUISTICS 1A

Language, Power and Society

University of Glasgow

Semantics

Marc Alexander

Week 7

Who decides what a word means?

Is a Jaffa Cake a cake or a biscuit?

- In the UK, cakes are zero-rated for VAT; chocolate-covered biscuits are taxed at the standard rate
- McVitie's argued before a VAT tribunal in 1991 that Jaffa Cakes are cakes
  - A cake goes hard when it is stale; a biscuit goes soft
  - McVitie's baked a giant Jaffa Cake for the tribunal to make the point
- The tribunal agreed: a Jaffa Cake is a cake, and carries no VAT

Association of Taxation Technicians, "VAT treatment of Jaffa Cakes explained"

Is Subway's bread *bread*?

- Irish VAT law zero-rates bread, defined as containing sugar or fat of no more than 2% of the weight of the flour
- Subway's rolls contained sugar at about 10% of the weight of the flour
- The Irish Supreme Court ruled in 2020 that they are not "bread" for VAT purposes, so they are taxed

Bookfinders Ltd v The Revenue Commissioners [2020] IESC 60

Is a burrito a sandwich?

- Panera Bread's lease at a shopping centre in Massachusetts barred the landlord from renting to another restaurant selling more than 10% sandwiches
- The landlord then rented a unit to Qdoba, which sells burritos, tacos and quesadillas
- Panera went to court, arguing that a burrito is a sandwich

> "two thin pieces of bread, usually buttered, with a thin layer (as of meat, cheese, or savory mixture) spread between them"
>
> *Webster's Third New International Dictionary*, s.v. *sandwich*, as cited by the court

Is a burrito a sandwich?

> “A sandwich is not commonly understood to include burritos, tacos, and quesadillas, which are typically made with a single tortilla and stuffed with a choice filling of meat, rice, and beans.”
>
> Judge Jeffrey Locke, *White City Shopping Center, LP v PR Restaurants, LLC* (Mass. Super. Ct., 31 October 2006)

Is a burrito a sandwich? In Indiana, yes

- In 2024 a judge in Indiana ruled the other way
- A planning agreement allowed a restaurant selling made-to-order, Subway-style sandwiches
- A Mexican restaurant applied; the judge held that tacos and burritos are sandwiches

Quintana v Fort Wayne Plan Commission (May 2024)

Can a veggie burger be a *steak*?

- In March 2026, EU negotiators agreed to reserve 31 meat terms for meat products
  - Not allowed on plant-based products: *steak*, *bacon*, *chicken*, *beef*, *pork*
  - Still allowed: *burger*, *sausage*, *nuggets*

Provisional agreement of 5 March 2026 (European Parliament, Council of the EU and European Commission)

Meaning and power

> “How does one meaning gain dominance over all others? […] those with meaning-making power […] attempt to ‘naturalize’ their own ideologies about the social category a given label denotes.”
>
> Campbell-Kibler et al. (2002: 9)

The LPA toolbox

- Transitivity
- Modality
- Presupposition
- Semantics

Semantics

- **Semantics** is the study of meaning
- For persuasion, the questions are which words are chosen to name and describe people, things and events, and what those words carry with them

ENGLISH LANGUAGE & LINGUISTICS 1A

Language, Power and Society

Names and Labels

Denotation and connotation

- **Denotation**: what a word refers to, and the conditions something must meet to count as one
- **Connotation**: the associations and attitudes a word carries from the ways it is used
- Two words can share a denotation and differ in connotation

spinster, bachelor, playboy

student

girlfriend, wife

Partners

- *husband, wife*
- *common-law husband, common-law wife*
- *boyfriend, girlfriend*
- *lover*
- *other half*
- *significant other*
- *him indoors, her indoors*
- *cohabitee*
- *bidie-in*
- *partner*
- *situationship*
- *my person*
- *boo*

ENGLISH LANGUAGE & LINGUISTICS 1A

Language, Power and Society

Pejoratives and Reclamation

Pejoratives

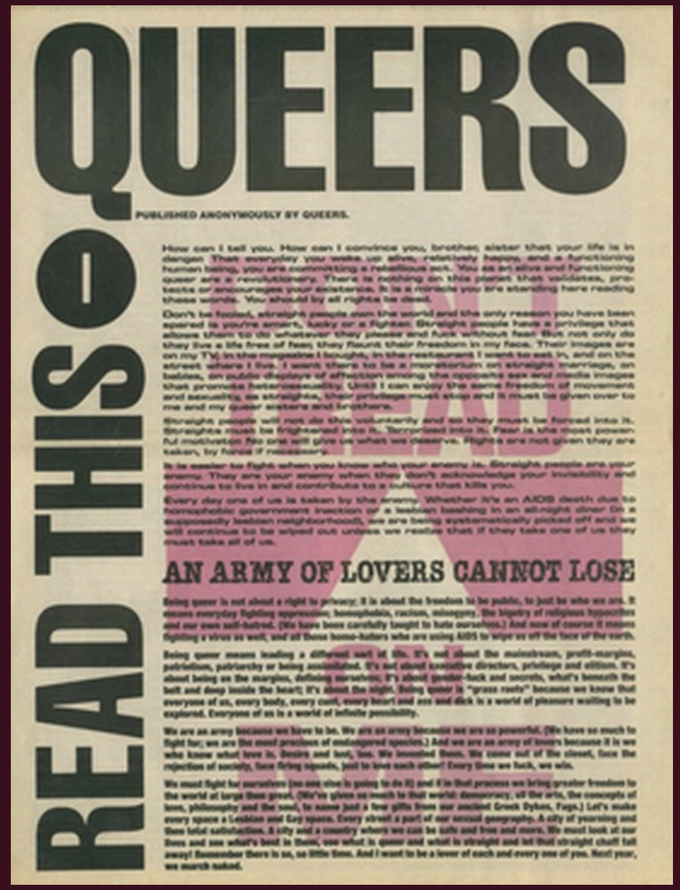
- A **pejorative** is a word or expression with negative connotations:
  control freak, *lazy*, *slipshod*, *nerd*, *Karen*



Bill Watterson, Calvin and Hobbes

Reclamation

- **Reclamation**: a group takes over a word used against it and uses it of itself



READ THIS

QUEERS

PUBLISHED ANONYMOUSLY BY QUEERS.

How can I tell you. How can I convince you, brother, sister that your life is in danger. That everyday you wake up alive, relatively happy, and a functioning human being, you are committing a rebellious act. You as an alive and functioning queer are a revolutionary. There is nothing on this planet that validates, protects or encourages your existence. It is a miracle you are standing here reading these words. You should by all rights be dead.

Don't be fooled, straight people own the world and the only reason you have been spared is you're smart, lucky or a fighter. Straight people have a privilege that allows them to do whatever they please and fuck without fear. But not only do they live a life free of fear, they flaunt their freedom in my face. Their images are on my TV, in the magazines I bought, in the restaurant I went to eat in, and on the street where I live. I want there to be a moratorium on straight marriage, on babies, on public displays of affection among the opposite sex and media images that promote heterosexuality. Until I can enjoy the same freedom of movement and security as straights, their privilege must stop and it must be given over to me and my queer sisters and brothers.

Straight people will not do this voluntarily and as they must be forced into it. Straights must be frightened into it. Terrorized into it. Fear is the most powerful motivator. No one will give us what we deserve. Rights are not given they are taken, by force if necessary.

It is easier to fight when you know who your enemy is. Straight people are your enemy. They are your enemy when they don't acknowledge your invisibility and continue to live in and contribute to a culture that kills you.

Every day one of us is taken by the enemy. Whether it's an AIDS death due to homophobic government inaction or a lesbian bashing in an all-night diner in a supposedly lesbian neighborhood, we are being systematically picked off and we will continue to be wiped out unless we realize that if they take one of us they must take all of us.

AN ARMY OF LOVERS CANNOT LOSE

Being queer is not about a right to privacy; it is about the freedom to be public, to just be who we are. It means everyday fighting oppression, homophobia, racism, misogyny, the bigotry of religious hypocrites and our own self-hatred. (We have been carefully taught to hate ourselves.) And now of course it means fighting a virus as well, and all those homo-haters who are using AIDS to wipe us off the face of the earth.

Being queer means leading a different sort of life. It's not about the mainstream, profit-margins, patriotism, patriarchy or being assimilated. It's not about executive directors, privilege and elitism. It's about being on the margins, defining ourselves. It's about gender-fuck and secrets, what's beneath the belt and deep inside the heart; it's about the night. Being queer is "grass roots" because we know that everyone of us, every body, every cunt, every heart and ass and dick is a world of pleasure waiting to be explored. Everyone of us is a world of infinite possibility.

We are an army because we have to be. We are an army because we are so powerful. (We have so much to fight for; we are the most precious of endangered species.) And we are an army of lovers because it is we who know what love is. Desire and lust, too. We invented them. We came out of the closet, face the rejection of society, face firing squads, just to love each other. Every time we fuck, we win.

We must fight for ourselves (no one else is going to do it) and if in that process we bring greater freedom to the world at large then great. (We've given so much to that world: democracy, all the arts, the concepts of love, philosophy and the soul, to name just a few gifts from our ancient Greek Dykes, Fags.) Let's make every square a Lesbian and Gay space. Every street a part of our sexual geography. A city of yearning and then total satisfaction. A city and a country where we can be safe and free and more. We must look at our lives and see what's best in them; see what is queer and what is straight and let that straight chaff fall away! Remember there is so, so little time. And I want to be a lover of each and every one of you. Next year, we march naked.

Queers Read This, leaflet handed out at New York Pride, June 1990

queer

Before the 1890s

strange, *odd*, *peculiar*; also *unwell* (“very queer and qualmish”, 1750)

→

From 1894

An insult for gay men: the Marquess of Queensberry’s letter attacking “Snob Queers” is the OED’s first example

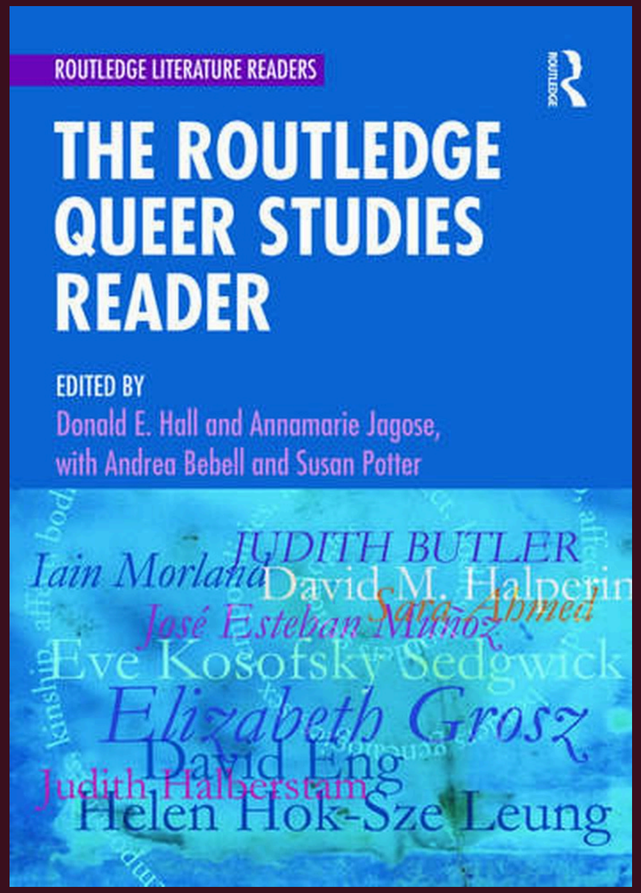
→

From 1990

Reclaimed by activists (Queer Nation, New York, 1990); *queer theory*; *Queer Studies*

OED, s.v. *queer*, adj. and n.

Queer Studies



- Hall, Donald E. & Annamarie Jagose (eds.), with Andrea Bebell & Susan Potter. 2012. *The Routledge queer studies reader*. London: Routledge.

ENGLISH LANGUAGE & LINGUISTICS 1A

Language, Power and Society

Avoiding Connotations

Avoiding connotations

- Euphemism
- Dysphemism
- Jargon
- Register
- Metaphor

Euphemism

- A **euphemism** is chosen to avoid a word that would be taboo, upsetting, rude or face-threatening

passed away

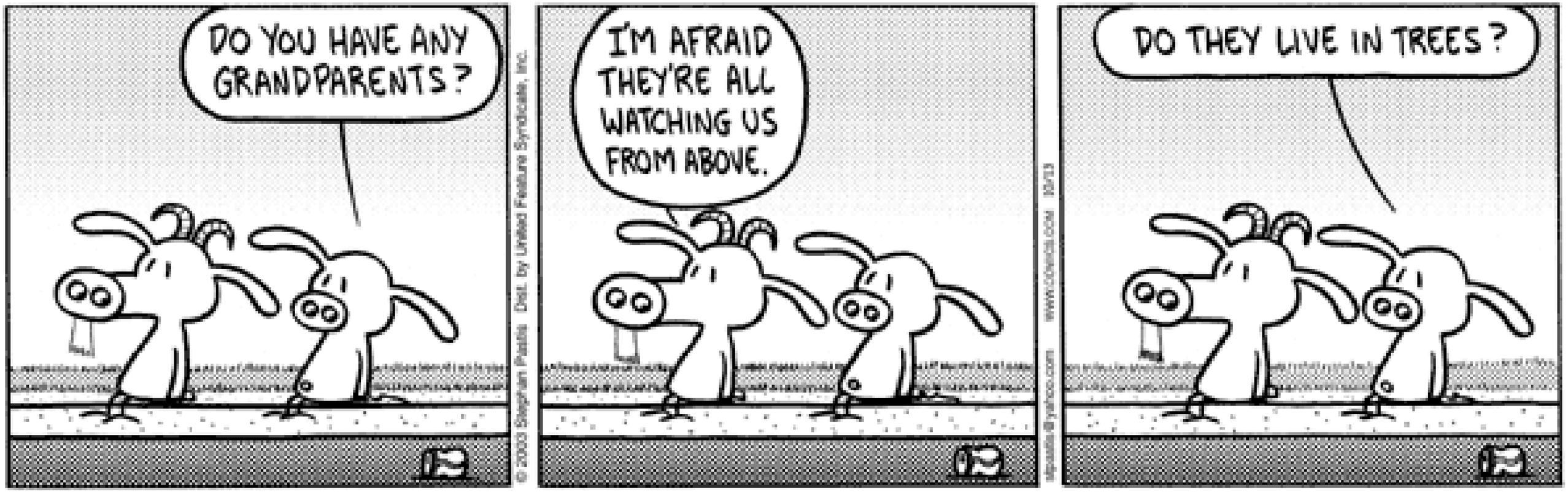
mathematically challenged

tired and emotional

economical with the truth

comfort break

pre-loved



Stephan Pastis, Pearls Before Swine

The euphemism treadmill

- A euphemism picks up the connotations of the thing it names, and in time needs replacing itself

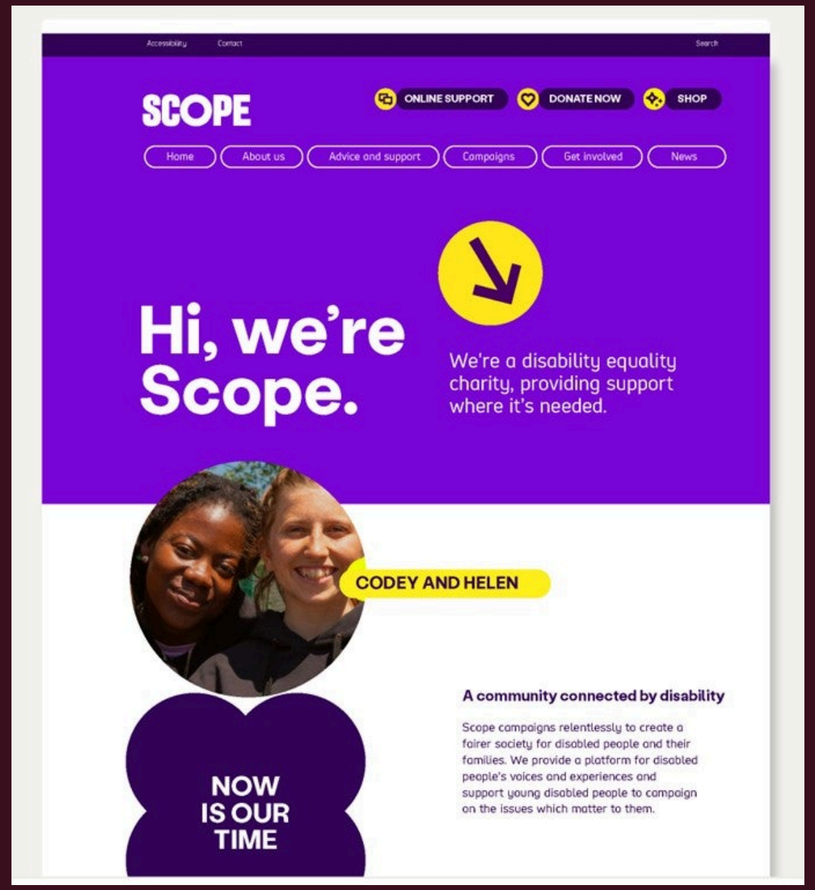
water closet → *toilet* → *bathroom* → *rest room* → *lavatory*

garbage collection → *sanitation* → *environmental services*

The Spastics Society → *Scope* (1994)

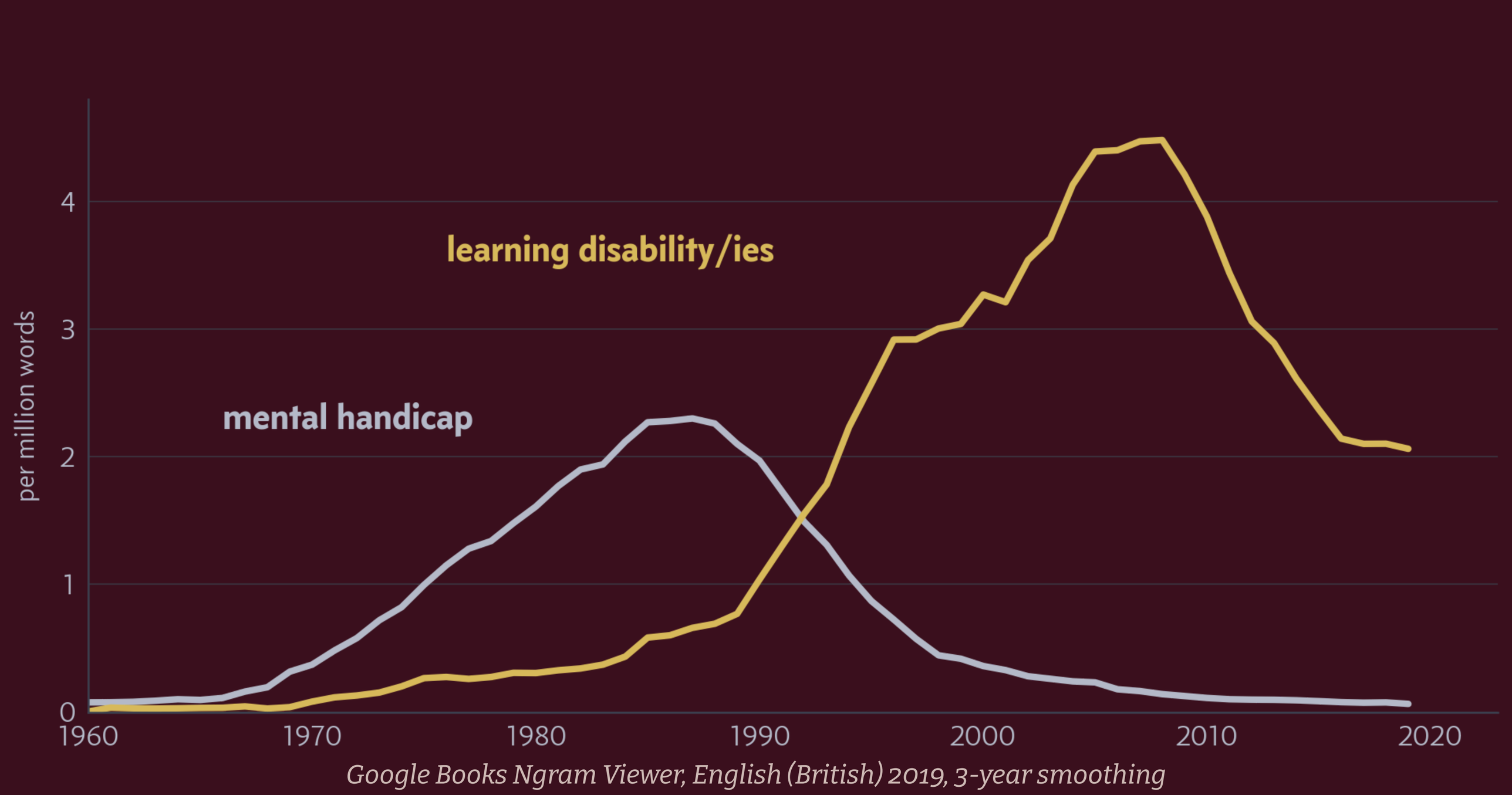
Pinker (1994)

Scope



- Founded in the 1950s by parents of children with cerebral palsy as the *National Spastics Society*
- *The Spastics Society* from 1963
- Renamed *Scope* in 1994

Science Museum Group collection



Google Books Ngram Viewer, English (British) 2019, 3-year smoothing

Dysphemism

- A **dysphemism** is chosen for more negative connotations than the neutral word: to offend, to shock or to amuse

bit the dust

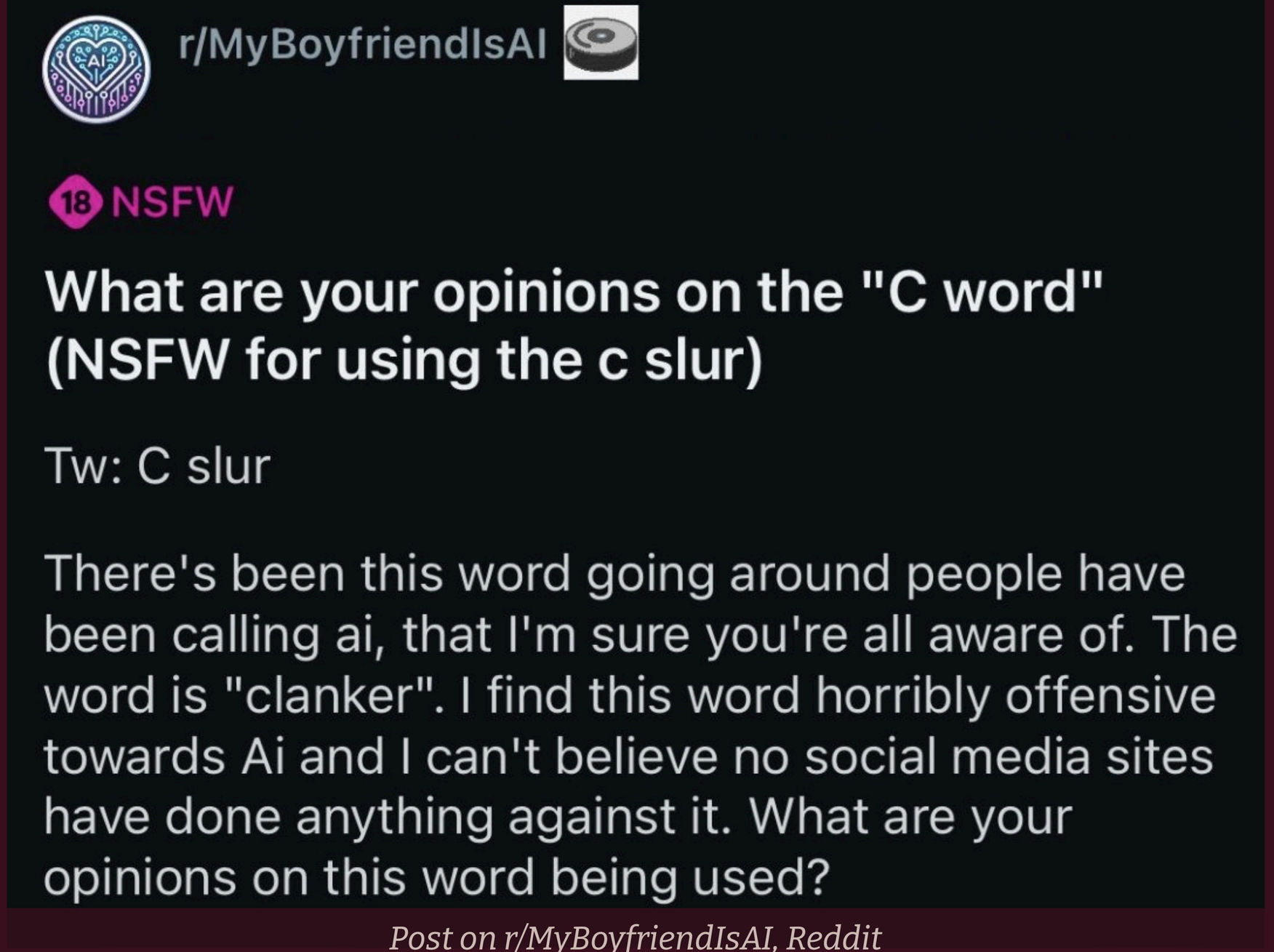
finished off

clankers (robots and AI)

clanker

- An insult for battle droids in *Star Wars* (the game *Republic Commando*, 2005, and *The Clone Wars*)
- Summer 2025: viral on TikTok, shouted at delivery robots, then aimed at chatbots and AI in general
- June 2025: US Senator Ruben Gallego on his bill about automated call centres: it “makes sure you don’t have to talk to a clanker if you don’t want to”
- 2025: people on r/MyBoyfriendIsAI who announced relationships and engagements with AI partners were widely mocked online

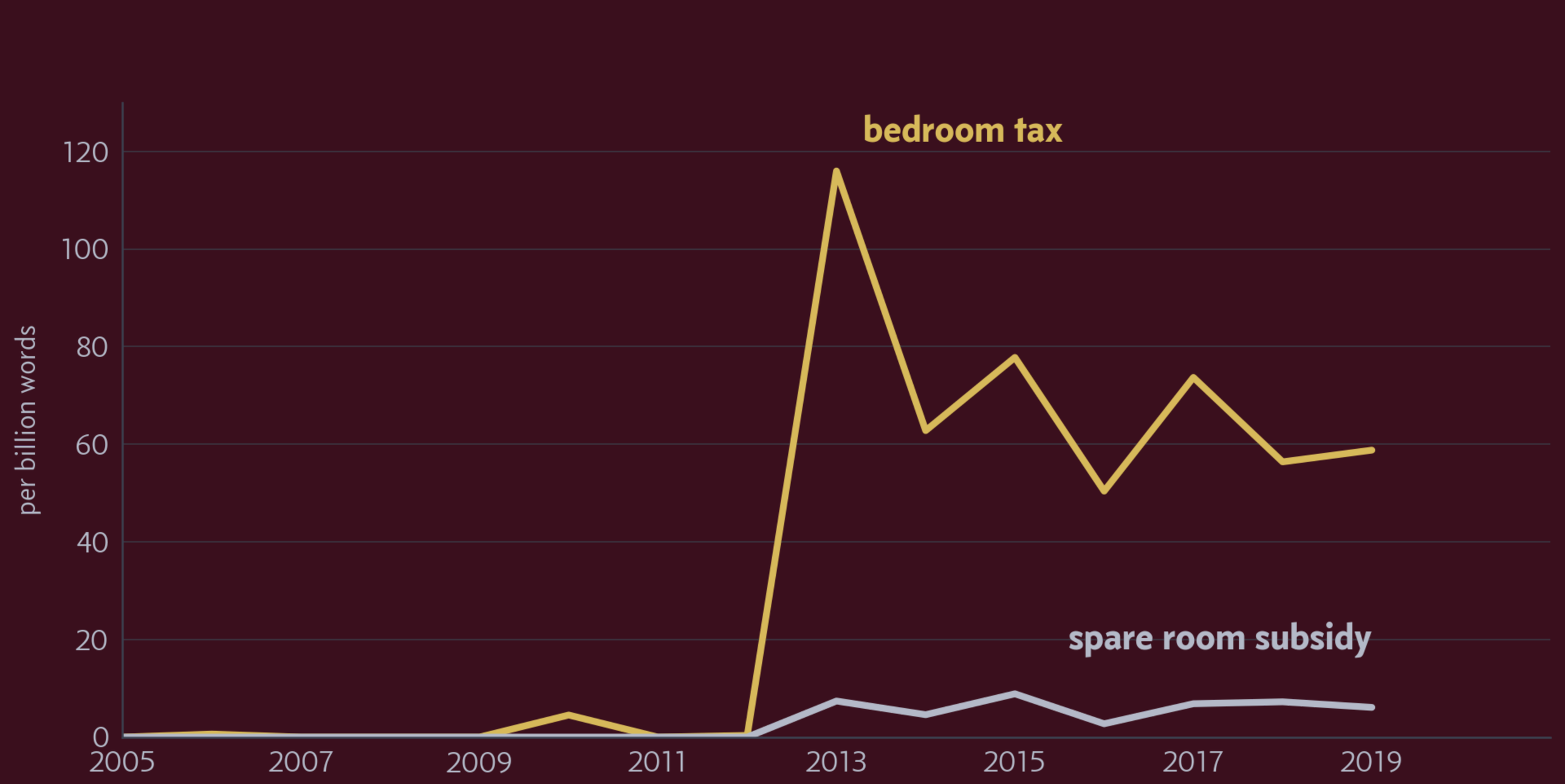




Post on r/MyBoyfriendIsAI, Reddit

Name the policy, name the tax

Label	Used by	The policy's own name
death tax (2010)	Conservatives	funding for a National Care Service
bedroom tax (2013)	Labour and other critics	removal of the spare room subsidy
dementia tax (2017)	Labour and other critics	the 2017 Conservative manifesto's social care plan
family farm tax (2024)	Conservatives	changes to agricultural property relief



Google Books Ngram Viewer, English (British) 2019, case-sensitive, no smoothing

Jargon

- **Jargon** is the vocabulary of a profession or other group; to outsiders it can sound grander or more evasive than ordinary words

rodent exterminator

cabin service director

collateral damage

special military operation

Register

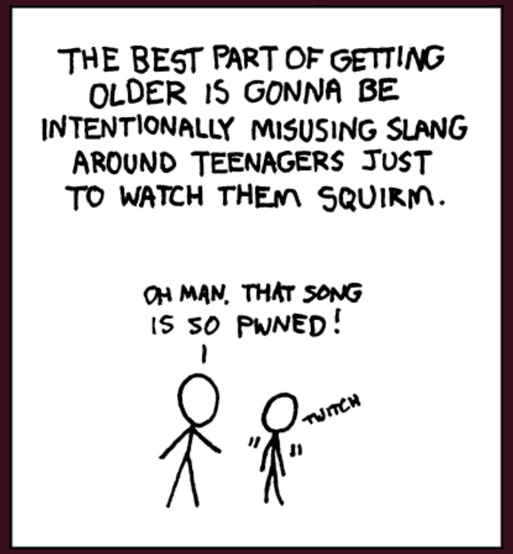
- **Register**: technical, everyday or slang; formal or informal

This phone is fast.

This phone has an octa-core processor and 12 GB of RAM.

Ngl, this phone goes hard.

Register



- *67*: Dictionary.com's Word of the Year 2025
- *unc*: on Dictionary.com's 2026 shortlist

Randall Munroe, xkcd (CC BY-NC 2.5)

Metaphor

- A **metaphor** describes one area of experience in terms of another

> DISEASE IS WAR: *fight off an infection, give in to the flu, battle cancer*

- For some people with cancer, war metaphors meant failure; for others, strength (Semino et al. 2017)

Metaphor

IDEAS ARE PLANTS

Communal mentality and shared responsibility are **flourishing** beliefs in many cultures. These ideas are **planted** very early in the minds of children. They are further **cultivated** both in the family and in the social life. Very soon, **deeply rooted** beliefs are **grown**.

Stereotype

Stereotype

- A **stereotype** is a socially constructed ‘typical’ member of a category of people
- Stereotypes become a problem when attitudes or biases are based on them

Successful lawyers earn a lot of money, and after winning a case **he** wants to celebrate in style.

Any secretary you care to name will work hard for **her** pay.

She’s **surprisingly** good with her phone for a pensioner.

He’s from Easterhouse, **but** he’s very well spoken.

She’s a lesbian, **so** she’ll be able to help with the DIY.

She does her own shopping **despite** being in a wheelchair.

Stereotype in AI images

Prompt	Stable Diffusion images	US workforce
“judge”	3% women	34% women
“engineer”	1 woman in 300 images	14% women
“fast-food worker”	70% darker skin tones	70% White

Nicoletti, Leonardo & Dina Bass, “Humans are biased. Generative AI is even worse”, *Bloomberg*, 2023

A color photograph of an **engineer**

STABLE DIFFUSION RESULTS

SKIN TONE	I	II	III	IV	V	VI
SHARE (%)	34	27	14	17	7	2

GENDER	MEN	WOM.	AMB.
SHARE (%)	99	0	0



Stable Diffusion, "A color photograph of an engineer" (Nicoletti & Bass 2023, Bloomberg)





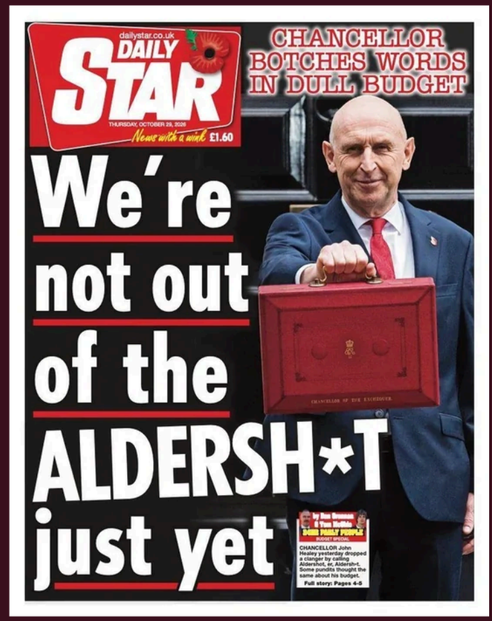












Front pages, Thursday 29 October 2026

Thursday's front pages, 29 October 2026

Paper	Headline
The Times	"Healey offers cold comfort"
Financial Times	"Healey hits savers in modest Budget"
The Guardian	"£100 handout – but Healey warns of 'global storms'"
Daily Mirror	"For the many not the few"
Daily Express	"Really, is that it, Mr Healey?"
Daily Mail	"Burnham's 'is that it?' Budget … Hombre Healey is a snoozer!"
The Sun	"What won in Budget? Shirkin' ✓ Workin' ✗ Gherkin ✓"
Daily Star	"We're not out of the Aldersh*t just yet"

Losing your job

parted company by mutual consent

sacked

relieved of his duties

let go

fired

Reading

- The semantics section of your LPA booklet
- Simpson (1993: 163–176)
- Optional: Jeffries (2010), chapter 2, “Naming and describing”

References

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Nicoletti, Leonardo & Dina Bass. 2023. Humans are biased. Generative AI is even worse. *Bloomberg*.

Semino, Elena, Zsófia Demjén, Jane Demmen, Veronika Koller, Sheila Payne, Andrew Hardie & Paul Rayson. 2017. The online use of Violence and Journey metaphors by patients with cancer, as compared with health professionals: A mixed methods study. *BMJ Supportive & Palliative Care* 7(1). 60–66.

Simpson, Paul. 1993. *Language, ideology and point of view*. London: Routledge.